

## Chapter 8

# V2 and V3 in Rhaeto-Romance varieties: Rethinking language contact

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The present contribution aims at re-evaluating the role of language contact in the emergence of V2 phenomena in Rhaeto-Romance varieties. Through a survey on the patterns of variation between V2 and V3 structures, the paper attempts (1) to determine the position of Rhaeto-Romance varieties within the spectrum of V2 languages devised by Cruschina & Sailor (2022), while also contextualising their development from Old Romance in accordance with Wolfe's (2019) diachronic typology, and (2) to verify whether it is possible to draw a direct correlation between higher degrees of language contact and stricter V2 constraints. If, from a general perspective, the varieties that are characterised by a closer and more prolonged contact with German (such as Swiss Romansh and the Ladin varieties of South Tyrol) generally appear to exhibit V2 more systematically, a closer scrutiny of the single varieties and their instances of micro-variation does not support the hypothesis of a direct proportionality between syntactic structures and language contact: other factors, such as information structure, appear to override the general predictions. Furthermore, as stated in Cruschina & Sailor (2022), the literature on the diachronic development of V2 has mostly been focused on the loss or preservation of V2, rather than its extension or emergence. The paper thus also takes into account examples of V2 structures that appear to be emerging among the youngest informants of the Rhaeto-Romance varieties lacking a significant exposure to German influence (namely Friulian, Fassan and Fodom). Cumulatively, these observations (1) suggest that the syntactic system of Rhaeto-Romance presents a general tendency to develop V2 (as argued by Kaiser & Hack 2013) and (2) confirm that language contact does not constitute a trigger for the emergence of V2 in Rhaeto-Romance. Rather, it can act as a catalyst for the retention or reinforcement of pre-existing features.



## 1 Introduction

### 1.1 Aim of the study

Since the publication of the monograph by Benincà & Haiman (1992), and later with the extensive work by Poletto (2000, 2002), the research concerning peculiar features of Rhaeto-Romance – given also its sociolinguistic and geographic position between Romance and Germanic – has often proven itself to be greatly beneficial for the deeper understanding of syntactical phenomena both on a synchronic and a diachronic level of analysis.

The purpose of the present contribution is to explore the issue of V2 and V3 word orders in Rhaeto-Romance varieties from a historical sociolinguistic perspective, with a specific focus on their relationship with Germanic varieties, whether Standard German or German dialects spoken in the area. Crucially, this paper does not aim at proposing a novel theory for the derivation or the representation of V2 and V3 structures in Rhaeto-Romance languages; rather, it strives at recontextualising them in light of the most recent developments in the research concerning the so-called “relaxed” and “residual” V2 languages.

### 1.2 Defining Rhaeto-Romance

Firstly, it is essential to understand what is meant by Rhaeto-Romance, which as a label has been varyingly applied to a number of languages and varieties throughout the history of the discipline.<sup>1</sup> In this paper, Rhaeto-Romance is used to refer to the following languages and their respective diatopic varieties:

- Romansh
  - Sursilvan (incl. Tuatschin)
  - Sutsilvan
  - Surmeiran
  - Engadinese (Jauer, Putèr, Vallader)
- Dolomitic Ladin
  - Gaderan (Badiot, Mareo)
  - Gardenese

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<sup>1</sup>For further discussion, see Benincà & Haiman (1992) and Salvi (2016). Varga (2009) provides an interesting study from a syntactic perspective. For a recent publication opposing the hypothesis of a cohesive Rhaeto-Romance family, see De Cia & Iubini-Hampton (2020).

- Fassan
- Fodom
- Friulian
  - Carnic
  - Western
  - Central-Eastern

While the genealogical connection between Rhaeto-Romance languages remains a matter of ongoing debate, these linguistic varieties collectively exhibit a set of – mostly conservative – features, effectively setting them apart from other Northern Italian and Gallo-Italic varieties. Conveniently, the issue is not particularly relevant for the purposes of the present study. Instead, the focal point resides in the intricate sociolinguistic and geographic context in which these varieties are spoken – regions characterised by substantial and prolonged language contact. It is also crucial to emphasise that, although official, these all constitute minority languages, with a rather limited number of speakers.

Indeed, Romansh is one of the four official languages of Switzerland (along German, French and Italian), counting approximately 60,000 speakers, mostly in the canton of Graubünden (rom. *Grischun*, fr. *Grisons*, it. *Grigioni*). Virtually all speakers are at least bilingual, with a majority of the population having German as an L2, and some cases of Italian as an L3. It should however be noted that, historically speaking, the language contact mainly involved the regional varieties of German and Italian, rather than the standard languages themselves. Contact with the Italo-Romance varieties is predictably more consistent in the southernmost part of the canton (Anderson 2016: 170).

The situation of Dolomitic Ladin<sup>2</sup> is equally interesting: Mareo, Badiot and Gardenese – collectively definable as northern varieties (Casalicchio 2020: 149) – are spoken in South Tyrol, a region characterised by a high degree of bilingualism, with a slight preponderance of the German element. On the other hand, the southern varieties Fassan and Fodom (also known as Livinallese) are, respectively, spoken in the regions of Trentino and Veneto, thus in an Italian-speaking

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<sup>2</sup>Dolomitic Ladin (sometimes referred to as *Sella dialects*) constitutes the best-preserved dialect subdivision of Ladin – which, depending on the theoretical framework of the different scholars, also includes the Agordo and Cadore dialects, as well as the Anaunico group – and the one that underwent deepest investigation. In earlier studies (such as Belardi 1991 and Benincà & Haiman 1992), the group also included Ampezan, which is now often considered to be a Cadore variety (see Salvi 2016: 155).

area. The approximate number of Ladin speakers is 25,000–30,000 (Salvi 2016: 156).

Friulian constitutes the language with the highest number of speakers (as many as 600,000<sup>3</sup>). The linguistic landscape of the Friuli-Venezia Giulia region is particularly fascinating: along with Italian and German, Friulian shares a border with Slovene, which also resulted in a number of loanwords (Spinozzi Monai 2015, Frau 2015).

## 2 V2 and contact in Rhaeto-Romance

### 2.1 Areal distribution

The question concerning the possibility of contact-related effects in V2 structures in Rhaeto-Romance thus arises from the observation of their distribution across the different varieties. Indeed, V2 appears to be more systematic in those dialects that are characterised by a more consistent contact with German. Consider the following examples from Benincà & Haiman (1992: 170–174):

(1) Sursilvan

Ed aschia fa=el il patg cul nausch  
and so makes=he the pact with.the devil  
‘Thus, he makes the pact with the Devil.’

(2) Putèr

Eir in Grischun vains nus industrias chi prodüan auncha memma  
even in Grisons have we industries that produce also too  
bger tössi per l’ ajer  
much poison for the air  
‘Even in Grisons, we have industries that produce too much poison in the air.’

The emergence of XVS order and the avoidance of V3 is therefore described as “general” across Swiss Romansh varieties. As observed later in the present paper, there are indeed certain contexts that license V3 in Romansh dialects and, to a certain extent, their areal distribution still appears to align with the varying degree of German contact (i.e., V3 is more frequent in Engadinese than elsewhere). Indeed, the same pattern is observed in Dolomitic Ladin:

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<sup>3</sup>According to the Regional Agency for the Friulian Language’s (Agjenzie Regionâl pe Lenghe Furlane) 2014 census.

- (3) Badiot  
 inshö e l alkol ruve a fa pert da nosta alimentatsiun  
 thus is the alcohol arrived to make part of our diet  
 ‘Thus alcohol has become a part of our diet.’
- (4) Gardenese  
 ilò a=l scumencià a mene na stleta vita  
 there has=he begun to lead a bad life  
 ‘There he began to lead a dissolute life.’
- (5) Fassan  
 dapò da sera, la vaces ju n stala i se perla  
 after at evening the cows down in stable they REFL talk  
 ‘Afterwards, in the evening, the cattle down in the stable talk among themselves.’
- (6) Fodom  
 Nte le Filippine mpruma l a mpare la lingua visaja  
 in the Philippines first he has learned the language Visayan  
 ‘It was in the Philippines that he first learned Visayan.’

The correlation between German or Italian influence and the presence or absence of V2 in main declarative clauses is quite apparent. Quoting directly from Benincà & Haiman (1992: 171):

The geographical distribution of this feature clearly suggests the importance of German influence: the closer to Bressanone/Brixen, the greater the influence of German; the closer to Trento, the less the influence of German.

Consistently with this view, no subject-verb inversion is found in main declarative clauses in Friulian:

- (7) Friulian  
 Une sabide matine il Pari Eterno al puarte a ciase un biel  
 one Saturday morning the Father Eternal he brings at home a fine  
 ciavret  
 kid  
 ‘One Saturday morning, the Eternal Father brings home a fine kid.’

Notably, all the Friulian examples provided by Benincà & Haiman (1992: 171) feature an initial Frame Setter – a quite pervasive V3 trigger, even in so-called

“strict” V2 languages (see e.g. Greco & Haegeman 2020) –, thus providing no information about the status of orders such as Adv-Subj-V.

A swift query on the CLAAP (Center for Applied Linguistics) Friulian Corpus<sup>4</sup> allows us to observe a few instances of V3 in main declarative clauses introduced by an adverb:

(8) Friulian

Imnò nissun sa che la fantate e je in cjase tò  
Still nobody knows that the girl she is in house your  
‘No one knows yet that the girl is in your house.’

On the other hand, compatibly with Benincà & Haiman’s (1992) description, no examples of V2 are found for adverb-introduced main declarative clauses.

The pattern is undoubtedly striking, initially leading to a quite widespread consensus concerning the relevance of German influence:

- The distribution of subject-verb inversion within Rhaeto-Romance strongly supports the hypothesis that XVS word order (whether in itself an inherited feature, as argued in Benincà 1985 and Vanelli 1984, or a later development, as suggested in Kuen 1957, Haiman 1974, and Hilty 1975) is a result of German influence (Benincà & Haiman 1992: 174).
- *Unser Phänomen tritt nur in den Gebieten auf, die stark von deutschen Mundarten geprägt wurden. [...] Aufgrund dieser Verhältnisse, insbesondere aufgrund der differenzierten Sachlage im Dolomitenladinischen, ist der Schluß zu ziehen, daß die Herausbildung dieses besonderen Systems der Inversion und der Inversionsformen im Rätoromanischen mit deutschem Einfluß in Verbindung zu bringen ist.*<sup>5</sup> (Linder 1987: 95).

## 2.2 Against the contact shortcut

However, the nature of such influence, as well as the modalities in which it operates, constitute a matter of debate. Indeed, especially in the early history of Rhaeto-Romance studies, many syntactic traits have been far too hastily described as being triggered by contact with German and its alpine varieties. This

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<sup>4</sup><https://claap.org/corpus-furlan/>

<sup>5</sup>“Our phenomenon appears only in those areas which have been strongly influenced by German dialects.[...]. Because of these circumstances, in particular because of the complex situation in Dolomitic Ladin one has to conclude that the evolution of this particular system of inversion and inversion forms in Rhaeto-Romance should be connected to German influence.”

is for example the case of Verb+Adverb constructions attested in Ladin, which were earlier described as a form of syntactic calque on German separable verbs (Plangg 1980).

(9) Gardenese

- a. *pensé do* (lit. “think behind”) < Ger. *nach-denken*, “to reflect”;
- b. *mëter pro* (lit. “put nearby”) < Ger. *zu-setzen*, “to add”.

(10) Badiot

- a. *tó sö* (lit. “take up”) < Ger. *auf-nehmen*, “to collect, record”;
- b. *odëi ite* (lit. “see inside”) < Ger. *ein-sehen*, “to understand”.

While these constructions display an undeniable resemblance with their German counterparts and constitute a significantly productive phenomenon, they represent lexical calques rather than syntactic ones. Indeed, such verbal constructions are also commonly found in other Northern Italian dialects that are not characterised by significant contact with German and, therefore, could not borrow a syntactic structure from it.

Furthermore, syntactic interference phenomena – especially in the form of borrowings and calques – are by themselves a highly debated subject, with prominent scholars within the generative framework (such as Baker 1996 and Longobardi 2001) deeming them to be marginal at best and utterly unconceivable at worst. Less extreme views allow contact-induced syntactic changes provided a superficial correspondence of the interested syntactic structures (Bidese 2023: 191) and/or a high degree of bilingualism (Benincà 1994: 98–99; cfr. Trudgill 2016: 318).<sup>6</sup>

However, such bilingualism did not actually characterise the majority of the Ladin community until the latter half of the 19<sup>th</sup> century (Belardi 1991: 135–141, Benincà 1994: 99). The hypothesis of the independent emergence of these forms is therefore confirmed by the observation of diachronic data from Old Italian and Old French (Cordin 2011: 84) as well as Ladin itself, where “phrasal verbs” are already attested in documents from the 16<sup>th</sup> and 17<sup>th</sup> centuries (Belardi 1991: 283).

In essence, caution is highly required when trying to ascribe the emergence of certain features to the effect of language contact, which – while not necessarily subordinated to other sources of language change – can only be reliably

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<sup>6</sup>See Harris & Campbell (1995: 121–150) for several examples of syntactic interference between typologically distant languages.

considered the triggering factor when no adequate internal factor can be individuated.<sup>7</sup> However, contact can contribute to the preservation or the spread of such features, as later discussed in the present study.

The same principle applies to the opposite situation, as in the case of Mòcheno, a Germanic language spoken in the Trentino region. The sociolinguistic situation of Mòcheno shares multiple points of resemblance with that of several Rhaeto-Romance varieties: it constitutes a speech-island and virtually all of its speakers (about 1,300) are bilingual. Therefore, many of its properties, such as so-called *relaxed* V2 (see below), have been considered to be an effect of language contact with Standard Italian and the neighbouring North Italian varieties. However, Cognola (2015) argues that V3 – as well as other syntactic traits such as Verb-Object order – cannot be attributed to “competing grammars”, i.e. the availability for the speakers to rely on different syntactic structures from different languages within their competence, as previously stated by Rowley (2003), among others.

Instead, taking syntactic contexts and informational structures into account, the V3 phenomenon found in Mòcheno differs consistently from both German and Italian. As explicitly stated in an earlier work (Cognola 2013):

contrariamente all’ipotesi che la variazione sia il risultato della presenza di due grammatiche in competizione – una conservativa di tipo tedesco, ed una innovativa di tipo romanzo – la distribuzione dei due ordini sintattici OV/VO [è] sensibile in mocheno al tipo di frase.

‘contrary to the hypothesis that variation is the result of the presence of two competing grammars – a conservative one of the German type and an innovative one of the Italian type – the distribution of the VO/OV syntactic orders in Mòcheno is sensitive to the sentence type.’

Besides providing a valuable explanation in terms of internal grammar that can be equally applied to the issue of V2 and V3 phenomena in Rhaeto-Romance, the previous quote also offers a valuable insight from a diachronic perspective.

Indeed, it can actually be argued that German syntax is not necessarily more conservative than the Romance one. In his typology of V2, Wolfe (2019) provides a categorisation of V2 through various diachronic stages of both Germanic and Romance languages, observing that deviations from V2 are indeed more frequently attested in Early Germanic and Romance languages than in their modern counterparts (Wolfe 2019: 3). Indeed, V3 is attested as late as the 15<sup>th</sup> century in Early New High German (Speyer 2008: 481):

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<sup>7</sup>For an in-depth discussion of the interplay between intra- and extra-linguistic factors see Far-  
rar & Jones (2002).



- (11) Early New High German, ca. 1450

Dar nach die edel kunginn fuer enhalb Ofen [...] mit grossem  
after that the noble queen went beyond Ofen [...] with great  
kummer  
concern

‘Thereafter the noble queen went, with great concern, beyond Ofen’

The construction displayed in the previous example is virtually identical to the one attested in the following Old Venetian sentence (Wolfe 2019: 11):

- (12) Old Venetian, 14<sup>th</sup> century

Unde Brat levà la man  
thus Brat raised the hand  
‘Brat then raised his hand’

### 2.3 A typology of V2

At this point, in order to avoid confusion, it is crucial to provide a brief terminological overview of V2. The most general description of the V2 property is probably the one proposed by Holmberg (2015: 375), involving two core components:

- A functional head in the left periphery attracts the finite verb.
- This functional head requires that a constituent be moved to its specifier position.

Following Wolfe (2019) I therefore assume that the left periphery is constituted by the following functional fields, as initially described by Rizzi (1997: 283):

[Frame.... [Force.... [Topic.... [Focus.... [Fin.... [TP.... ]]]]]

The detail that concretely sets apart the so-called strict and relaxed V2 languages is the functional head that attracts the finite verb: this is Force in the case of strict V2 (virtually all the standard Germanic languages with the exception of English) and Fin in the case of relaxed V2 (such as Old Romance and Early Germanic).<sup>8</sup>

<sup>8</sup>However, Catasso (2024) argues for the classification of Modern German as FinP V2. Within Early Germanic, Old Saxon already shows strong tendencies towards generalised V-to-Force<sup>0</sup> movement as early as the 9<sup>th</sup> century (Walkden 2015: 15–29). An alternate account of strict vs. relaxed V2 based on the feature scattering hypothesis (Giorgi & Pianesi 1997) is proposed by Hsu (2017).

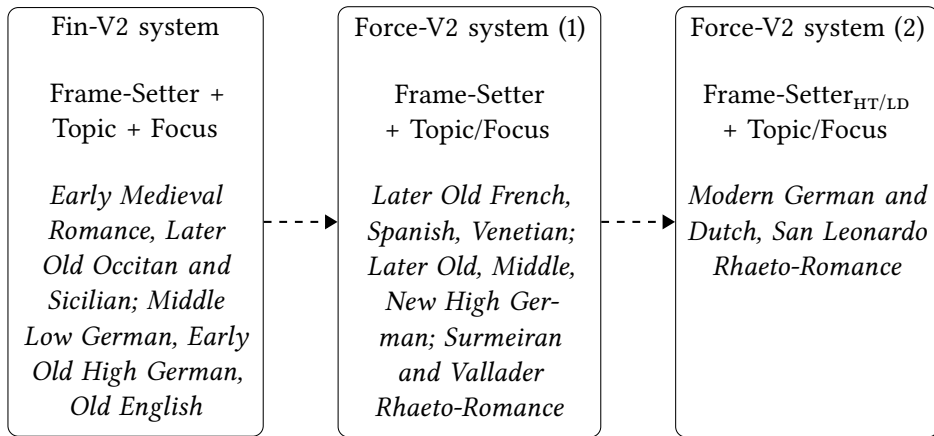


Figure 1: Types of V2 systems (Wolfe 2019: 14).

As shown in Figure 1, according to Wolfe’s (2019) typology, Rhaeto-Romance languages are classified within two subsets of strict V2. Surmeiran and Vallader are listed as type 1 Force-V2 languages in which the verb, moved to Force, can be only preceded by a Frame Setter and a topicalised or focussed element:<sup>9</sup>

(13) Surmeiran

La seira anturn las nov Tina sa prepara per sorteir  
the evening around the nine Tina REFL prepares to go.out  
‘In the evening around nine, Tina gets ready to go out.’

(14) Vallader

in quel istess mumaint il trid uorsin as transmüdet in ün bel  
in this same moment the ugly bear REFL transforms in a handsome  
prinz  
prince  
‘In this moment the ugly bear changed into a handsome prince.’

On the other hand, the Badiot dialect of San Leonardo (extensively analysed by Poletto 2000, 2002) only licenses V3 when the first of the two preverbal constituents is expressed as a Hanging Topic (HT) or via Left Dislocation (LD):

(15) Badiot (S. Leonardo)

L liber, a Giani ti l’ai bel dé  
the book, to Giani it have=I already given  
‘I already gave the book to John.’

<sup>9</sup>Notice the similarity between these two utterances and the examples in (11) and (12).

The data from S. Leonardo is therefore in contradiction with the contact hypothesis, since Romansh varieties (or at least Surmeiran) would be expected to exhibit stricter V2 constraints. As shown later, more complex and reliable data will emerge through the closer observation of the singular varieties.

For the purposes of this paper, a further difference is marked between *partial* V2 and *residual* V2, as defined in a fairly recent contribution by Cruschina & Sailor (2022):<sup>10</sup>

- A language displays a *partial* V2 system if the only clause types in which V2 emerges are non-declarative.<sup>11</sup> Although V2 is only exhibited in limited environments, its derivation still follows the rules described in Holmberg (2015) and the language is considered to be a V2 language.
- A language displays *residual* V2 if some syntactic environments display superficial V2 order as a vestige of an earlier stage when the language exhibited Full V2 (i.e. either strict or relaxed V2, see figure below). However, in this case, the derivation of the structure does not involve V-to-C movement and the subsequent movement of a constituent to its specifier position. Thus, the language is not considered to be a V2 language.

According to this framework, despite displaying a superficially analogous word order in *wh*-questions, Modern English qualifies as a partial V2 language (since it exhibits V2 in a limited set of environments), while the Modern Romance languages are considered as residual (thus non-) V2, as summarised in Figure 2.

## 2.4 Partial and residual V2 in Rhaeto-Romance

Once such categories have been defined, it is possible to place the different Rhaeto-Romance varieties on this spectrum according to their behaviour and to verify if a relationship between such behaviour and the degree of contact with German varieties exists. Let us start from Fassan, Fodom and Friulian which, as previously observed, display no V-to-C movement in main declarative clauses, thus not qualifying as Full-V2 languages according to the proposed terminology.

Munaro (2011: 180–182) proves quite convincingly that the subject (clitic)-verb inversion attested in Central-Eastern Friulian in a rather wide set of non-declarative clauses – mostly connoted by an attitude of uncertainty or disbelief regarding the content of the proposition (see also Poletto 2000) – is expressed through

<sup>10</sup>Notice that this typology may differ greatly from previous accounts relying on the same or similar labels (e.g. Rizzi 1996 or Klævik-Pettersen 2022).

<sup>11</sup>By the authors' own admission, the "non-declarative" label requires further refinement, since English also exhibits V2 in a limited set of declarative clauses (see Sailor 2020: 127).

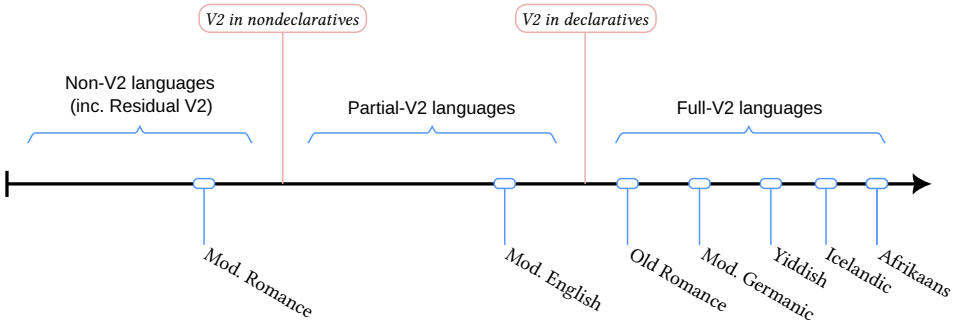


Figure 2: V2 Spectrum (Adapted from Cruschina & Sailor 2022).

the raising of the inflected verb to a functional head in the C-layer. Consider the following examples:

(16) Central Friulian

- a. *ce mi toci=al di vjodi!*  
 what me-obj.cl touches=it of see  
 ‘What am I forced to see!’
- b. *ti vess=jo dit la veretât!*  
 you-obj.cl. had=I told the truth  
 ‘Had I only told you the truth!’
- c. *vinisi=al tjo pari, o podaresin là*  
 came=he your father, we could go  
 ‘If your father came, we could go.’

If Munaro’s observation is correct, then Friulian (or at least its Central-Eastern variety) does indeed satisfy the first requirement for V2. However, the second requirement – i.e. the attraction of a constituent to the specifier position of this functional head – only appears to be overtly satisfied in (16.a). A V2 analysis for the latter examples is possible under the assumption – shared e.g. by Haegeman (1995: 98–99) and Grosz (2012: 254) and included in Wolfe’s (2019: 20) typology – of a covert operator serving as XP1 in non-declarative clauses such as optatives/exclamatives (16.b) and conditionals (16.c). Thus, superficial V1 orders are analysed as having an underlying V2 structure:

- b.  $[OP]_{XP1} \text{ ti vess=jo } v_2 \text{ dit la veretât!}$
- c.  $[OP]_{XP1} \text{ vinisi=al } v_2 \text{ tjo pari [...]}$

From this perspective, Friulian can therefore be considered a partial V2 language within Cruschina & Sailor's (2022) framework.<sup>12</sup>

Despite being based on the same stimuli as (16), the currently available data for Fassan – retrieved from the AThEME Verona-Trento Corpus (Tomaselli et al. 2022) – are unfortunately elusive to a direct comparison. That is because Fassan features an incomplete subject clitic paradigm (Hack 2012: 47) and subjects lacking a clitic form can be omitted, while 3<sup>rd</sup> person clitics (both singular and plural) are only obligatory in the absence of an overt subject (Salvi 2016: 164).<sup>13</sup> Furthermore, the 1<sup>st</sup> person plural enclitic subject *-e* is phonetically identical to the verb ending in (17c).

(17) Fassan

- a. Che che me tocia veder!  
What COMP me-obj.cl touches see  
'What am I forced to see!'
- b. Te aesse dit la verità!  
you-obj.cl. had.1.SING told the truth  
'Had I only told you the truth!'
- c. Se ruasse to pare podassane partir  
If came.3.SING your father could.1.PL. go  
'If your father came, we could go.'

As anticipated in Section 2.1, the standard literature (Benincà & Haiman 1992: 171, Salvi 2016: 164) does not account for XVS orders in Fassan and Fodom. Compatibly with these descriptions, no such orders are attested for sentences introduced by conditional (map 101) or concessive (map 301 and 511) clauses on the ALD-II (Dolomitic Ladin Atlas, Goebel et al. 2012) either. The *wh*-COMP sequence displayed in (17a) is traditionally described as being limited to the Brach and Cazet varieties of Fassan, where it is also found in partial interrogatives as an alternative to the more conservative *wh*-V-S.cl. order. This feature, as well as other instances of SV orders in interrogative clauses, has been interpreted by Hack (2012: 183) as evidence of the highly residual V2 status of Brach and Cazet.

<sup>12</sup>Arguably, such requirements are also satisfied by several Venetan dialects, displaying verb raising in progressively smaller subsets of the environments (Munaro 2011: 187). This once again suggests that researchers ought to be extraordinarily careful before ascribing syntactic phenomena to the effect of German influence.

<sup>13</sup>Salvi (2016: 164) actually states that 3<sup>rd</sup> person clitics are obligatory in the absence of preverbal subjects. However, in main declaratives with a fronted object, subject clitic omission is preferred by 2/3 informants in the corpus, as in *el caffè lounch no lo tol so fra, ma so mare*.

On the other hand, in the same contexts, Moenat – the remaining Fassan variety – displays obligatory Subject-Verb inversion and is thus considered to feature a stricter V2-proprity.<sup>14</sup>

Despite the limited sample, an informal survey conducted on seven Fassan speakers produced interesting results. The task consisted in the translation of the same stimuli provided in Italian. Firstly, the two Moenat participants (both between 30 and 40 years of age) translated the sentence as “*Che che me tocia veder!*”, thus producing the wh-COMP sequence that was unattested in Moenat at the time of Hack’s (2012) account. It is thus possible that the phenomenon is currently spreading into Moenat as well, or has done so over the course of the last decade. Secondly – and more relevantly to the purposes of this paper – two informants (60 and 44 years old, respectively from Vigo di Fassa and Campitello) produced V-S.cl. order, as in “*Che me tochel veder!*”. Further investigations featuring a larger sample and including purposefully devised stimuli (in order to avoid ambiguous responses) will certainly provide valuable insight into the more recent developments of Fassan.

Fodom and Fassan display identical strategies for the formation of the (pseudointerrogative) exclamative (18a) and conditional (18b). Similarly to Fassan, the inverted order in (18b) constitutes an unexpected result, which is also completely unattested on the ALD-II (informants born between 1919 and 1953). Subject clitic inversion was exclusively produced by the youngest of the two Fodom speakers in the ATHEME Verona-Trento Corpus (respectively born in 1989 and 1964). The same speaker also reformulated the conditional in (18c) as a desiderative: “*ruasse-lo pur to pere!*”, once again displaying V-S.cl. inversion.

(18) Fodom

- a. Ci    che    me            toca    vedei!  
       What COMP me-obj.cl touches see  
       ‘What am I forced to see!’
- b. T’            es-io            pur    dit    la    verité!  
       you-obj.cl. had-1.SING even told the truth  
       ‘Had I only told you the truth!’
- c. Se vegnisse    to    pere    podonsa    parti  
       If    came.3.SING your father could.1.PL. go  
       ‘If your father came, we could go.’

<sup>14</sup>The fact that it is precisely the variety of Moena, that in closest contact with Italian and non-Ladin dialects, to have retained a more conservative word order in these contexts has been explained by Hack (2012: 234) in terms of *Überentäußerung* (over-renunciation), i.e. an higher resistance to language interference on the very edges of the bordering areas.

Although the unquestionable scarcity of data hinders the possibility of making broader statements, the pattern is undoubtedly striking. The traditional accounts for Fassan and Fodom as residual V2 varieties apply to virtually all the speakers born until the late 50's, while younger speakers manifest a stronger tendency towards V2. However, without a larger sample of speakers from both areas and without further data concerning non-declarative clauses (or other environments) featuring obligatory subjects in Fassan, it is currently impossible to determine whether Fassan and Fodom could represent a partial V2 variety as it has been proposed for Friulian. If further findings were to confirm these tendencies towards the extension of V2 orders, that would bear significant implications both for the contact hypothesis (since the areas are not characterised by contact with German) and the V2 typology of Rhaeto-Romance as a whole.

## 2.5 V3 in strict-V2 Rhaeto-Romance varieties

### 2.5.1 Romansh

Having discussed the status of the Rhaeto-Romance varieties on the left-end of the V2 spectrum, let us now consider the instances of V3 and their contexts in the varieties with a higher degree of contact with German.

The data found in Romansh seems to, at least partially, counter the assumption of a proportional adherence to German syntax. V3 of the kind S-Adv-V appears to be only attested in Sursilvan (19) – the Romansh variety in closest contact with German – but ungrammatical in Surmeiran (20):

- (19) Sursilvan (Samo 2019: 10)

Jeu bunamein sedurmentel

I almost fell.asleep

'I almost fell asleep'

- (20) Surmeiran (Anderson 2016: 14)

el saleida curtaschevlamaintg igl plevant

he greets courteously the minister

'He greets the minister courteously.'

On the other hand, Surmeiran differs from the other varieties by lacking inversion of the element *ins* (< lat. UNUS) used for impersonal constructions, even in interrogatives. Notice the absence of inversion with *ins*, as opposed with the second *igl* ("they") in the following sentence (Anderson 2016: 23):

- (21) Surmeiran  
Ainten chell'ustareia ins na magl igl betg schi bagn, on igl detg.  
Inside that=inn one not eat it not so well, have they said  
'They said one does not eat too well in that inn.'

As opposed to Sursilvan and Putèr (*ün* is the impersonal pronoun in the latter):

- (22) Sursilvan  
Nua en ins cun la lavur? Alla fin en ins mai.  
Where is one with the work? At.the end is one never  
'At what point are we with the work? We're never done.'
- (23) Putèr  
Passand tres il desert chatta ün qualchevoutas skeletons.  
Passing across the desert finds one sometimes skeletons  
'Walking across the desert, you may sometimes find skeletons.'

Anderson (2006: 19–20) thus argues that Surmeiran *ins* does not occupy subject position, rather it behaves like a preverbal clitic, similarly to the reflexive impersonal constructions found in Italian and Spanish.<sup>15</sup> This statements bears considerable implications about the V2 status of Surmeiran as a whole, since “non-inverted” impersonal declaratives as in (24) would then license a V1 structure, which ultimately leads Anderson to deny a V2 grammar for Surmeiran.

- (24) Surmeiran  
Ins na pò betg eir quant spert tg'ins vot sen las autostradas  
one NEG can.3SG not go as fast that=one wants on the freeways  
svizras  
Swiss  
'You can't go however fast as you want on the Swiss freeways'

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<sup>15</sup>A peculiar aspect of the divergent behaviour of Surmeiran is that, while some speakers do accept inversion with *ins*, the resulting sentence is perceived as “sounding like German” (Anderson 2016: 24). This is further proof that in multilingual environments, even if a structure is featured (and potentially acceptable) in the speaker's competence, the supposed presence of “competing” grammars does not necessarily have to result in the adherence with the structures of the *Dachsprache*. On the contrary, the speakers may – more or less consciously – display forms of hyperdialectalism, favouring features that emphasise the differences between the two languages. The phenomenon is well attested and analysed in the field of Scandinavian dialectology, where it is known as *naboopposisjon* (neighbour opposition). For an overview see Jahr (2017).



To this respect, it is legitimate to object that verb-initial orders are well attested both in Old Romance (Wolfe 2015) and Early Germanic (Hinterhölzl & Petrova 2010). Furthermore, V1 is attested in impersonal clauses even in rather strict V2 languages such as Icelandic.

While not directly involving verb-subject orders, the next few examples allow for some relevant observations concerning the diachronic development of Romansh in relation to its contact with German.

Sursilvan differs from the rest of Rhaeto-Romance by lacking clitic pronouns (Benincà & Haiman 1992: 125), that were otherwise present in Old Sursilvan at least until 1718:

- (25) Vallader (*La Soncha Scrittüra*, 1953)

Tü m'hast clamà  
you me=have called  
'You have called me.'

- (26) Sursilvan (*Vegl Testament*, 1967)

Ti has clamaui mei  
You have called me  
'You have called me.'

- (27) Sursilvan (*Bibla da Cuera*, 1718)

Ti mi=has clumau  
you me=have called  
'You have called me.'

The loss of clitics in Sursilvan has been mentioned as a suitable example of German influence (Ascoli 1883, Stimm 1973). However, cross-linguistic observation suggests that such development can also be triggered by language-internal factors: Brazilian Portuguese, in contrast to its European counterpart, is indeed undergoing loss of object clitics.<sup>16</sup> The diverging developments of European and Brazilian Portuguese, which by themselves do not appear to be motivated by language contact in general, are clearly not motivated by contact with a Germanic language (Kaiser & Hack 2013: 92–93).

The syntax of Tuatschin (a Sursilvan variety spoken by around 900 people) is extensively described in Mauer-Cecchini's (2021) grammar. According to his account, the V2 system of Tuatschin appears to be rather strict and quite comparable to German. However, when presenting one single instance of V>2, the

<sup>16</sup>Second person objects are systematically expressed with non-clitic object pronouns. The shift also applies to third person objects in colloquial Brazilian Portuguese (Duarte 2000).

author states that if “a subject which would normally be inverted is focalised, it may occur preverbally” (Mauer-Cecchini 2021: 225):

(28) Tuatschin

[A lur scha'l vès ussa pagljau in grép tga vès pudju bétar èl]  
[and then if=it had now hit a rock that had could throw it]  
[scha]quèls fissan grat schulaj gjà ajl'aua  
[then] these would immediately fall down into=water  
'And then if it [the load] hit a rock that could have thrown it down, these  
[the mules] would have immediately fallen into the water.'

According to the available literature, Tuatschin quite uncontroversially qualifies as a strict V2 variety. Kaiser (2002: 328) argues that such structures (also found in different diachronic stages of Sursilvan and Engadinese) are analogous to forms of *wenn...dann* dislocation found in German, where a whole subordinate clause is displaced and the adverbial coreferent “*scha*” appears as the first constituent in the main clause. V3 orders introduced by a resumptive element are well attested in contemporary colloquial German (Wiese & Müller 2018).

Finally, instances of a Frame Setter being followed by the subject and the verb are found in both the main Engadinese varieties (Samo 2019: 152). With temporal Frame Setters (29b, 30b), Vallader differs from Putèr by only allowing V3 via subject focalisation:

(29) Vallader (Oetzel 1994: 157–159)

- a. Prö üna chasa da vaschins üna merla ha fat seis gnieu  
On a house of neighbours a blackbird has made her nest  
'On one of the houses of the neighbours, a black bird made its nest.'
- b. Fin a quel di ingün nu'm vaiva mai dit il  
Until to that day nobody NEG.ME=OBJ.CL had never said the  
cuntrari  
opposite  
'Until that day, nobody told me the opposite.'

(30) Putèr (Oetzel 1994: 161)

- a. Nodvart l'alp Givannes evra a la fin la buocha  
This.side.of the=alps Givannes opened finally the mouth  
'Once on this side of Alps, Givannes finally started talking.'
- b. Uossa Ciglia la clama  
Now Ciglia her=calls  
'Now Ciglia calls her.'

Table 1: Deviations from V2 in Romansh varieties.

|           | S-Adv-V | Impersonal V1 | Frame-S-V        | PP-S-V |
|-----------|---------|---------------|------------------|--------|
| Sursilvan | +       | –             | – <sup>(a)</sup> | –      |
| Sutsilvan | –       | –             | –                | –      |
| Surmeiran | –       | +             | –                | –      |
| Vallader  | –       | –             | +/- <sup>b</sup> | –      |
| Putèr     | –       | –             | +                | +      |

<sup>a</sup>Except for constructions with a resumptive element and a focused subject in Tuatschin (27).

<sup>b</sup>Only via subject topicalisation with a temporal Frame Setter.

Furthermore, Putèr distinguishes itself from the other Romansh varieties by allowing a topicalised PP to precede the subject (focused or otherwise) and the inflected verb:

(31) Putèr

- a. a Ludwig ils ögls haun cumanzo a glüschir  
to Ludwig the eyes have started to glow  
‘Ludwig’s eyes started glowing.’<sup>17</sup>
- b. ma da que üngün nu s’ho inachüert ünguotta  
but of that nobody NEG REFL=have noticed nothing  
‘But no one noticed anything about that.’

Through this overview of Romansh varieties, some preliminary conclusions can be drawn. While, on a macroscopic level, the different degrees of adherence to XVS point towards a correlation with the neighbouring languages, deeper investigations and the observation of microvariation prove that further factors that can disrupt such a linear analysis are at play. Table 1 provides an overview of the contexts that deviate from V2 in the different Romansh varieties. While it is still possible to place the different varieties on a spectrum according to their contact with German or Italian, some phenomena elude this interpretation.

Firstly, independent developments within the singular varieties can bring to deviations even in those that appear to have a stricter V2 systems, as in the case

<sup>17</sup>At first glance, one might interpret the initial PP as expressing a possessive relation within a complex DP ([a Ludwig [ils ögls]]). However, the PP denotes a contrastive topic, a more fitting translation might be “as for Ludwig, his eyes started to glow”.

of S-Adv-V orders in Sursilvan (19) and verb-initial impersonal declaratives in Surmeiran (24). Secondly, although V3 in Engadinese varieties seems to be proportional with their distance to Italian, its licensing is also strongly affected by factors as informational structure and the type of the fronted constituent. Thus the observed data hinders the complete acceptance of Kaiser's (2002: 330) claim that:

Die regelmäßigen Abweichungen von der Verb-Zweit-Stellung beschränken sich im Bündnerromanischen weitgehend auf Dislokationsstrukturen und auf Kontexte, in denen durch die Versform die syntaktischen Stellungenregeln gelockert sind. Im Alt- und Mittelfranzösischen hingegen sind Abweichungen von der Verb-Zweit-Stellung nicht auf solche Kontexte beschränkt.

'The regular deviations from the verb-second position in Romansh are largely limited to dislocation structures and to contexts in which the syntactic position rules are relaxed by the verse form. In Old and Middle French, on the other hand, deviations from the verb-second position are not limited to such contexts.'

It should be mentioned that Kaiser's study is solely based on biblical material, thus no reliable comparative analysis between verse and prose is provided. Indeed, many of the V3 structures analysed by Kaiser are found in the spoken language as well, such as examples (29–31). Some further critique of Kaiser's method and claims will be presented in the conclusions.

Finally, the fact that loss of object clitics in Sursilvan can be determined by language-internal factors (as suggested by the analogous phenomenon in Portuguese), contrasts Oetzel's (1994: 169) statement that without the assumption of contact phenomena "there is no other way to explain why in Sursilvan and Sursilvan – two idioms that have less contact with Italian – the VS serialisation is observed more consistently than in Engadinese".<sup>18</sup>

### 2.5.2 Ladin

After providing such an overview of the Romansh varieties, it is now possible to move forward with the analysis of variation within (northern) Dolomitic Ladin.

<sup>18</sup> Anders ist nicht zu erklären, weshalb im S und Ss – zwei Idiomen, die weniger Kontakt mit dem Italienischen haben – die VS-Serialisierung konsequenter beachtet wird als im Engadinischen" Notice, however, that Oetzel is assuming a strict V2 as the starting point for Romansh in general and attributing the deviations from V2 found in Engadinese to Italian influence.

The following examples are primarily excerpted from Casalicchio & Cognola's (2018) survey on micro-variation within Ladin varieties.

The first example of V3 is represented by a Frame setter followed by a focalised subject, as produced by a Gardenese speaker:

(32) Gardenese

Te butëiga mami à for cumprà la farina  
in shop mum has always bought the flour  
'It was always mum who bought the flour in the shop.'

Although this construction is commonly accepted, V2 still constitutes the preferred alternative among Badiot speakers and the only acceptable one for the Mareo informant, contrarily to predictions based on the degree of contact with German:

(33) Badiot

Te botëga à tres la mama cumprè la farina  
in shop has always the mum bought the flour  
'In the shop, mum has always bought the flour.'

As observed for the Engadinese varieties, a significant role is played by the informational structure of the utterance. Indeed, V3 is the preferred option when the subject is not focalised:

(34) Badiot

Inier Maria à cumprè i soni  
yesterday Maria has bought the potatoes  
'Yesterday Maria bought the potatoes.'

The following construction – consisting of a fronted object and a focused subject – results in V2 being accepted by the Mareo speaker and one of the Badiot informants interviewed in Casalicchio & Cognola's survey. However, although accepted, V2 is not spontaneously produced by any of the speakers.<sup>19</sup> Indeed, the two main structures produced either consist of a Left Dislocation (as also found in Italian) (36) or no inversion at all (35).

<sup>19</sup>Regrettably, the Mareo speaker did not complete this task and incorrectly translated the sentence contained in the following task. While their acceptance of V2 and the absence of a spontaneously produced alternative suggests their preference for V2 in a context featuring a fronted object and a focused subject, no comparable inference can be brought forward for an analogous context without focus on the subject.

- (35) Badiot  
 La lëtra al foliet la uma ti à scrit  
 the letter to.the newspaper the mum it.OBJ.CL has written  
 ‘It was mom who wrote the letter to the newspaper.’
- (36) Gardenese  
 La lëtra tla zaita l’ à scritta la l’oma  
 the letter to.the newspaper OBJ.CL has written the mum  
 ‘It was mom who wrote the letter to the newspaper.’

V2 was produced by one of the Badiot informants when presented a sentence with a fronted object and no focalised subject. Similarly to the previous context, the rest of the Badiot speakers tend to produce a structure without inversion, while the Gardenese speakers produce a LD resembling Italian:

- (37) Badiot  
 Le liber la uma l’à cumprè inier  
 the book the mum it=has bought yesterday  
 ‘Mom bought the book yesterday.’
- (38) Gardenese  
 L liber l à cumprà la l’oma inier  
 the book it=has bought the mum yesterday  
 ‘Mom bought the book yesterday.’

The provided results are summarised in Table 2.

Table 2: V3 licensing in the northern Ladin varieties

|           | Frame <sub>-Foc</sub> Subj-V | Frame-Subj-V | Front <sub>Obj</sub> -FocSubj-V | Front <sub>Obj</sub> -Subj-V |
|-----------|------------------------------|--------------|---------------------------------|------------------------------|
| Mareo     | –                            | –            | ?                               | ?                            |
| Badiotto  | +/-<br>(V2 preferred)        | +            | +                               | +                            |
| Gardenese | +                            | +            | +                               | +                            |

### 3 Final remarks: Rethinking contact

As previously mentioned, while – on a macroscopic level – the distribution of V2 and V3 orders within Dolomitic Ladin seems to point to the effect of contact either with German or Italian, the closer observation of instances of variation among speakers of the same variety highlights how the alternation between V2 and V3 is also related to the informational structure of the utterance and to sociolinguistic factors. These observations, along with the description of (1) deviations from V2 in the Romansh varieties and the language-internal factors that drove their development and (2) previously unattested V2 orders in Fassan and Fodom, lead us to reconsider and redefine the role of language contact in the emergence or retention of V2 in Rhaeto-Romance.

As stated in Cruschina & Sailor (2022: 18), the scholarship on the diachronic development of V2, especially in the Romance area, has mostly been focused on the *loss* or *preservation* of V2, rather than its *extension*. This perspective justifies Kaiser's (2002: 331) claim that Romansh V2 cannot be interpreted as the preservation of an earlier Old Romance stage (represented by Old French).<sup>20</sup> While this point is perfectly solid, there are some methodological aspects that might benefit from reconsideration.

Kaiser (2002) proposes a comparison between the changes in frequency of XVS orders in the different diachronic stages of French and Romansh (in particular Sursilvan), observing a considerably higher frequency both in Modern and Old Romansh when compared to Old French, thus excluding the hypothesis of V2 preservation. However, it is crucial to highlight that – given that the first written attestations of Romansh are rather recent – the label “Old” Sursilvan is used to describe the language contained in the Bible translation of 1718, while the Old French translation consulted by Kaiser dates back to the 12<sup>th</sup> century. The frequency of XVS in Old Sursilvan is actually quite comparable to the 1494 Middle French translation (22.8% vs. 26.8%).

Applying a diachronic-typological perspective such as that proposed by Wolfe (2019), the assumption that both French and Romansh syntax developed from an Old Romance type, characterised by a relaxed V2 system, appears perfectly plausible. Such a system would then evolve in different directions: one characterised by the progressive loss of V2 (as in most Romance languages), the other by its expansion as in the case of Romansh and other Rhaeto-Romance varieties. Crucially, French had initially undergone a similar expansion of V2 (Later Old French

<sup>20</sup>“Dies führt zu der Schlussfolgerung, dass die im Bünderromanischen existierende Verb-Zweit-Stellung nicht als ein “Überbleibsel” einer erb-Zweit-Stellungseigenschaft angesehen werden kann, die ursprünglich in den romanischen Sprachen allgemeine Gültigkeit gehabt haben soll.”

is in fact mentioned as a type1 Force-V2 system in Wolfe's typology, cfr. fig.1). Unlike the rest of Romance, a more precise chronological subdivision of the process in Rhaeto-Romance is unfortunately hindered by the late date of the first written attestations.<sup>21</sup>

The contact with German and its regional varieties, which were undergoing (or had already undergone) a similar development of V2 strengthening (as observed in Speyer (2008)), therefore contributed to its expansion in Rhaeto-Romance varieties, rather than triggering it. Thus, rather than Germanic influence, it would be appropriate to define the process as *contact-induced grammatical reinforcement*, i.e. the further spread of shared syntactic traits that were already independently developing in both language groups because of their similar starting syntactical proprieties.

An analogous process is described by Cordin (2011: 84–85) regarding the aforementioned topic of Verb+Adverb constructions. Contact with German did not cause the emergence of the construction in Romance varieties, rather it “attracted the phenomenon to the other end of the [grammaticalisation] spectrum”. Furthermore, contact-induced grammatical reinforcement is not limited to the domain of syntax but has been observed in other levels of analysis, such as morphology. Trudgill (2016: 322–323) shows that the Old English two-copula system (*wesan-beon*) reflected a semantic nuance – distinguishing habitual vs. non-habitual “to be” – identical to that found in Celtic. The contact between West Germanic and Celtic languages, coupled with the presence of this shared lexical and semantic trait, contributed to the preservation of the two copula stems, ultimately resulting in the suppletive inflection of the verb “to be” in present-day West Germanic.

In conclusion, V2 in Rhaeto-Romance varieties is far from a cohesive phenomenon, and not one that can be swiftly accounted for as a form of syntactic Germanism. While the presented data is compatible with an hypothesis of contact-induced grammatical reinforcement, resulting in the development of a strict V2 system in areas characterised by a high degree of Romance-German bilingualism (especially in the last three centuries), a more insightful analysis of the diatopic, sociolinguistic, discourse-related and speaker-internal variation that results in deviations from V2 confirms that the phenomenon arose independently in the different languages (possibly as a common development from a SOV order attested both in Latin and Early Germanic). Additionally, the new attestations of

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<sup>21</sup>It is however interesting to notice that, according to Kaiser's (2002: 325) investigation, the strengthening of V2 in Sursilvan appears to be a rather recent development, since the percentage of XVS orders almost doubled between 1718 and 1967. While, by itself, this detail provides no sufficient chronological evidence, it does not clash with other observations concerning the timeline of contact with German and its supposed effect, as later discussed.



seemingly V2 orders in Rhaeto-Romance varieties that are not characterised by an equally strong and lasting contact with German varieties (such as Fassan and Fodom) could serve as a further proof of a general tendency of Rhaeto-Romance to develop a V2 system, as assumed in Kaiser & Hack (2013):

strong contact with German has caused the emergence of a strong V2 order in Swiss Romansh in a situation where a tendency to develop such a word order already existed before.

Thus, further research on micro-variation within Rhaeto-Romance will undoubtedly provide valuable insight on the validity of contact-related hypotheses and the syntactic environments in which they can operate.

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